

Strategy & Recommendations

— Options Brainstorm

May 9, 2026 · Architect: Ava · Reviewed: Richard

TL;DR

The dashboard's gym strategy currently assumes **canonical Pokémon Platinum rosters** — surfaces tell you "Crasher Wake uses Water — bring Grass/Electric." In **randomized Nuzlocke runs** (the user's actual mode) those rosters are shuffled, so the leader-specific advice is wrong roughly half the time. Separately, **"coverage" is rendered in four live places** (PARTY sidebar, center PARTY tab, PC BOX rail, STRATEGY tab) plus a fifth in dead code, with subtle drift between them.

Five options were considered, ranging from total deletion to a per-run mode toggle. **The architect's pick is Option C — pivot to roster-only / type-chart-only strategy.** Delete `pixeldex_gym_strategy`, reuse the existing `pixeldex_team_dialog` helper to put a roster-derived "TYPE READINESS" line in the NEXT BATTLE panel. Universally valid in randomizer runs, ~1 day of work, no new schema.

OPTIONS

Option A Delete leader-specific strategy entirely

CLOSE 2ND

REMOVED	<code>pixeldex_gym_strategy/2</code> helper. Six call-sites. The "↓ NEXT BATTLE" prep line. The five footer "dialog" boxes across GYMS / MAP / STRATEGY / MAP-rail / STRATEGY-tab.
KEPT	Everything else. NEXT BATTLE panel still shows LEADER · CITY · Lv 37 (those are facts, not advice — the leader's name and level cap are correct from the badge bitfield even in randomizer). All coverage / weakness / balance-notes surfaces stay (they read user roster). <code>gym_ready</code> page untouched. Discord bot untouched.
ADDED	Nothing.
USER-VISIBLE	The NEXT BATTLE right-rail loses its 2-line strategy paragraph and gains nothing. The four center-tab "dialog" footers just disappear. The dashboard feels marginally emptier on those tabs, but the actually-useful surface (NEXT BATTLE CTA + START GYM DRAFT button) is preserved.
EFFORT	~0.5 days. Helper delete + 6 call-site removals + spec updates + small CSS tidy where empty <code>.dialog</code> divs leave dead margins.

Honest read of the resulting emptiness: the NEXT BATTLE card becomes LEADER · CITY · Lv 37 + a CTA — pure facts plus the action the user wants to take. The four center-tab dialog footers were always afterthoughts; deleting them would not be missed.

Option B **Replace canonical with user-entered scouting**

STRIKE

REMOVED	Canonical <code>gym_info.yml</code> <code>type</code> and <code>ace</code> fields as inputs to strategy text (level cap and leader name kept as labels — load-bearing).
KEPT	Everything Option A keeps.
ADDED	A "SCOUT GYM LEADER" surface where the user inputs leader-name override (optional) and 1–6 mons (species + level), then strategy reads from that. New schema (<code>gym_scouts</code> table or JSON column on <code>gym_results</code> / <code>soul_link_runs</code>), new modal, new helper that computes coverage gaps vs. the scouted team using <code>TypeChart.weaknesses_for</code> .
USER-VISIBLE	Per-leader data-entry chore before each gym. New "SCOUT" button on the GYMS tab.
EFFORT	~3–4 days. Schema + migration + modal UI + Stimulus species autocomplete reuse + helper rewrite + spec coverage.

*The brief explicitly flags this kind of friction as a non-starter ("manually maintaining a per-leader roster table before strategy can be useful is a non-starter"). Pre-battle data entry across four players, eight gyms, every run reset, is exactly the chore the brief rejects. **Strike this.***

Option C Pivot to roster-only strategy

RECOMMENDED

- REMOVED

`pixeldex_gym_strategy/2` (same as A). Plus: the per-gym "TYPE" labels — "WTR" / "ICE" — across `_status_rail.html.erb:152`, `_gyms_content.html.erb:51,70,124`, `/map/show.html.erb:55,67,163`. Same canonical-Platinum claim wearing a different costume.
- KEPT

All `TypeChart.analyze_team` outputs (coverage, gaps, shared weaknesses, balance notes, type distribution). All gym leader names + level caps (factual — driven by badge count, not leader rosters). MARK BEATEN flow. `/gym_ready` full page.
- ADDED

A pure-roster **"TYPE READINESS"** callout in the NEXT BATTLE panel, computed from `@type_analysis` only — e.g., "TEAM HAS GAPS: ICE, FGT" or "FULL OFFENSIVE COVERAGE." This is what `pixeldex_team_dialog` already produces; reuse verbatim in NEXT BATTLE instead of `pixeldex_gym_strategy`.
- USER-VISIBLE

NEXT BATTLE shows the same advice the PARTY dialog already shows, but inside the gym-prep panel. The visible "what types should I pack" message stays — it just no longer pretends to know what the leader has.
- EFFORT

~1–1.5 days. Helper consolidation (rename `pixeldex_team_dialog` → gym-aware name; swap call sites), remove `type` columns from gym list rows, spec updates, plus CSS tidy on now-empty `.dialog` divs (carry-over from Option A).

Why C over A: the NEXT BATTLE panel is exactly where the user is staring before pushing START GYM DRAFT. Answering "you have ICE and FGT gaps" is a true, useful answer in a randomizer run. Pure deletion would leave the panel as metadata + CTA — fine, slightly less useful. C reuses code that already exists; the marginal cost over A is rounding error.

Option D Mode toggle (Vanilla / Randomized / Scouted)

STRIKE

REMOVED	Nothing structural.
KEPT	Everything.
ADDED	- soul_link_runs.gym_mode enum column (vanilla , randomized , scouted) + migration. Default randomized . - Branching in pixeldex_gym_strategy and the per-gym list type label: vanilla → today's behavior; randomized → roster-only output; scouted → reads new gym_scouts table (Option B's surface). "RUN SETTINGS" UI row on the runs management surface — toggle. - Backfill / migration story for existing runs.
USER-VISIBLE	New settings affordance per run. Same dashboard otherwise unless the user picks vanilla.
EFFORT	~3–5 days. Schema + migration + backfill + 3 helper branches + settings UI + tests. Keeps the bad code path alive forever, gated on a flag almost no one will flip back to.

The "don't decide" option. Encodes both the broken behavior and the correct behavior in one codebase, leans on a setting nobody will tune, and adds three permutations to every future strategy-related change. **Strike unless the PO genuinely believes vanilla-roster runs are a real audience.**

Option E Auto-scout via SRAM / randomizer JAR		DEFER
INSPIRATION	The 2026-05-02 SRAM auto-tracking audit documents how to read the player's PARTY block from a save. Same machinery, applied post-gym, <i>could</i> capture a leader's roster — except SRAM stores the player's mons, not the opponent's. There is no realistic offset that records "what Crasher Wake's team looked like." That path is a dead end.	
ADJACENT FEASIBLE	Auto-snapshot the player's team at gym-beat moment (already covered by category 2 of the SRAM audit). Writes <code>gym_results.team_snapshot</code> when <code>parsed_badges</code> increments. Useful for "what beat this gym," but doesn't answer "what should I bring."	
REAL FUTURE OPTION	The app already invokes the Universal Pokémon Randomizer JAR (<code>app/services/soul_link/rom_randomizer.rb</code>) — capturing the JAR's spoiler/log output is the natural data feed for trainer rosters and doesn't require user upload. Still future work; flagged for completeness.	
REMOVED / KEPT / ADDED / EFFORT	N/A — defer. Auto-roster-detection of opponents is a feature unto itself and is out of scope for this rethink.	

COMPARISON

OPTION	TITLE	WHAT'S REMOVED	WHAT'S KEPT	EFFORT	VERDICT
A	Delete it all	Helper + 6 call-sites + 5 dialog footers	Leader name, city, level cap, all roster-driven coverage	~0.5 d	CLOSE 2ND
B	User-entered scouting	Canonical roster as strategy input	Same as A	~3–4 d	STRIKE — FRICTION
C	Roster-only strategy	Helper + 6 call-sites + per-gym "TYPE" labels	All TypeChart outputs, leader/city/level, gym_ready	~1–1.5 d	RECOMMENDED
D	Mode toggle	Nothing structural	Everything (plus 3 branches forever)	~3–5 d	STRIKE — BLOAT
E	Auto-scout (JAR/SRAM)	—	—	future	DEFER

SOURCE DOCUMENTS

Full proposal — including the surface inventory, duplication map, dedup pass, and open questions for the Project Owner — lives at `handoff/2026-05-09-strategy-recommendations-rethink.md`

Reviewer's pressure-test (verdict: **READY WITH NOTES**, 0 Blocker / 2 Major / 3 Minor) lives at `handoff/REVIEW-FEEDBACK.md`